

For years, Sihanouk considered what he called the Khmers Rouges little more than a nuisance. They remained a small, isolated group of extreme zealots, nurturing their own vision of “pure” revolution and extolling suffering and sacrifice. It was a rural-based agrarian communism roughly modeled on Mao Zedong’s peasant movement.

The extreme secrecy of the Khmer Rouge made it a mystery to most Cambodians, who referred to it as the “forest army.” In its camps deep inside the countryside, the Khmer Rouge leadership created a strike force of teenage soldiers, described by one witness as “grim, robotlike, brutal.”

Unintended consequences

Operation Menu, which was launched by the United States in March 1969, upset the political balance in Cambodia. The Khmer Rouge took advantage of the weakness in Phnom Penh under Sihanouk and subsequently Lon Nol, and the spread of the Vietnam War to Cambodia to expand their membership among disaffected rural Cambodians. Although Nixon had bluntly declared that “no Cambodians had lived in [the area bombed] for many years” and that “it was totally occupied by the North Vietnamese Communists,” American intelligence knew otherwise. Terrified villagers fled the B-52 attacks, and some of the survivors ended up in the ranks of the rebels. Those who did not join the militants became sympathetic to the enemies of the United States. Very young, displaced villagers were radicalized and trained as guerrillas.



Khmer Rouge guerrillas

Few photographs exist of Khmer Rouge soldiers in their camps in the 1960s and 1970s. Pictured at their base in western Cambodia in February 1981, these Khmer Rouge guerrillas are as young and committed as those of earlier decades.

Strange bedfellows

The overthrow of Sihanouk by conservative factions of the ruling class, led by Lon Nol, created a moment of opportunity for the Khmer Rouge. They now found it expedient to form an alignment with the ousted prince whom they had long opposed and with the